

# Deciduous Flowering Shrubs — Agent-Grade Care Narrative (Priority Tagged)

Purpose: agent-readable horticultural narrative for generating care schedules and cautions. Priority tags: P1=survival-critical, P2=establishment success, P3=optimization, P4=advanced/reference. P1 statements are conservative and exception-aware.

## A. Site & Light Requirements (P1)

- Match plant tag; many flowering shrubs need full sun to part sun for best bloom; shade reduces flowering.
- Provide afternoon shade for heat-sensitive types in very hot climates if label indicates.

## B. Temperature & Climate Constraints (P1)

- Plant only when soil is workable (not frozen/waterlogged).
- Establishment best in moderate temps; treat prolonged >90°F (32°C) as high-risk during first month.
- Late frosts can damage early growth/buds; protect if freeze is forecast soon after planting.

## C. Seasonal Timing / Planting Window (P1)

- Best planting: autumn to early spring when soil isn't extremely wet or frozen.
- Container-grown shrubs can be planted outside that window with higher aftercare.
- Avoid planting in hot/dry weather; avoid peak winter in frozen/waterlogged soils.
- Mild-winter exception: winter planting acceptable if soil workable and irrigation available.

## D. Watering & Moisture Profile (Day 0–30) (P1)

- Water in thoroughly at planting.
- Days 1–14: check moisture daily; water deeply when top few inches are dry.
- Typical establishment schedule: Weeks 1–2 daily; Weeks 3–12 every 2–3 days; then weekly until established (adjust for rain/soil).
- Avoid soggy soils; pause irrigation after heavy rains.

## E. Soil Requirements (P2)

- Well-drained soil preferred; amend broadly rather than heavily amending only the hole in heavy clay.
- pH varies by species (e.g., hydrangea color effects); follow tag where relevant.

## F. Planting & Installation Rules (P1)

- Root flare at grade; firm soil to eliminate air pockets.
- Mulch 2–3 inches, keep away from stems.
- Do not prune heavily at planting; remove only dead/broken wood (pruning timing depends on bloom habit).

## G. Fertilization Guidance (P1)

- Avoid quick-release fertilizing at planting; rely on good soil prep.
- Fertilize only after establishment/active growth and only when soil moisture is adequate; prefer slow-release or compost.

## **H. Pest & Disease Risk (Early Window) (P2)**

- Aphids can appear on tender growth; strong water spray is a first response.
- High humidity + overhead watering can increase foliar disease; water at base.

## **I. Weed Competition Sensitivity (P2)**

- Maintain a mulched, weed-free ring; hand-pull weeds close to stems to avoid root disturbance.

## **J. Weather Exception Handling (P1)**

- Heat wave: increase watering frequency; consider temporary shade for stress-prone species.
- Frost: cover tender new growth/buds; water before freeze only if soil is dry and above freezing.
- Heavy rain: pause watering; ensure drainage within 24 hours.

## **K. Growth & Establishment Signals (P2)**

- Normal: temporary wilt that recovers after watering; slight leaf yellowing from transplant shock.
- Concerning: ongoing wilt in wet soil, blackened stems, rapid leaf drop.

## **L. Safety & Customer Guardrails (P1)**

- Do not plant into frozen or waterlogged soil.
- Do not prune 'for shape' immediately after planting (can remove flower buds).
- Do not fertilize drought-stressed plants.

## **M. Location-Based Modifiers (P2)**

- Cold zones: prioritize spring planting or early fall with sufficient time before hard freeze.
- Warm zones: fall/winter planting often preferred to avoid summer stress.

## **N. Lifecycle Transition (Post 30 Days) (P4)**

- Species-specific pruning and feeding schedules apply after establishment; follow bloom habit (old wood vs new wood).